CHAPTER 29

DEEP BREATHS

Andy Flower has brought new things into the set-up of the England squad. For one, he mentions during a team meeting that Mark Bawden – a sports psychologist – will be joining the staff and will be around often. His idea is that whereas sports teams have begun to bring in psychologists when something goes wrong, in versions of emergency rescue packages, he thinks it will be helpful to have Mark around regularly in a positive capacity, to help with performance rather than being reactive. Flower reasserts to us, as he does, that we cannot reach number one in the world without a group of players that are the best in the world at what they do, and Mark might be able to help with that.

Mark explains at training that he is going to be around and will be working with us individually whenever we need, whether things are going well or badly. He asks whether he can have a coffee with each of us. I am the only player who decides they would rather not. Mark is tiptoeing around me in the dressing room like I'm a caged lion over the next few weeks, giving me space but trying to find a way to communicate. He eventually braves it, walks up to me and says:

'Jimmy, I'd love to come and speak to you about how we might be able to get you to the next level.'

'How are you going to do that,' I say, 'if you don't know me?' He says it's a fair point and we make a deal that in six months' time, when he has been around, seen how I operate and observed some cricket, there might be something he can tell me about my own mind. Trust has started to become a big issue for me as my appearances for England become more regular. The way the nurses asked for my autograph in the hospital was uncomfortable then, and more uncomfortable as I live with it, and my world has begun to